COMPLETE BEGINNER'S COURSE

Shopify and E-commerce Career Course

From business foundations to building a career in online retail with Shopify

14 chapters · Designed for learners with basic computer knowledge · No coding experience required

Edition: November 2026. Shopify features, plans and fees change over time; check current details on shopify.com before making decisions.

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A Glossary of Terms

Each chapter has: a short introduction, the core concepts with tables and drawings, a common mistake to avoid, key takeaways, and a practice task. Work through the chapters in order; the capstone in Chapter 14 brings every earlier chapter together.

CHAPTER 1

Welcome to E-commerce and Shopify

> Before you touch a single setting, you need a clear picture of what an online store is, how money and goods move through it, and where Shopify fits. This chapter gives you that picture and the vocabulary you will use for the rest of the course.

1.1 What is e-commerce?

E-commerce means buying and selling goods or services over the internet. The most common forms are:

Type	Meaning	Example
B2C (business to consumer)	A business sells directly to a person	A clothing brand selling sneakers from its own website
B2B (business to business)	A business sells to another business	A packaging supplier selling boxes to restaurants
C2C (consumer to consumer)	People sell to each other, usually through a platform	Selling second-hand furniture through a classifieds site
Marketplace	One platform hosts many sellers	Amazon, Daraz, eBay, Etsy

Shopify is built for merchants who want to run their **own store**: a branded website with its own customers, prices, and data. You can still sell on marketplaces through Shopify, but your store is the centre of the business.

1.2 Why Shopify?

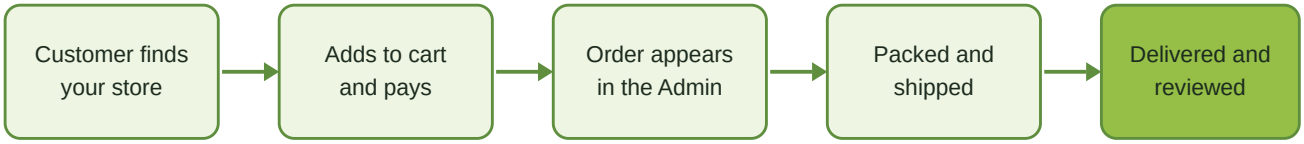
Shopify is a hosted e-commerce platform. You pay a subscription, and Shopify runs the servers, security, updates, hosting, checkout and payment processing for you. This matters for a beginner for four reasons:

- **Speed to launch.** A working store with a checkout can be live in a day or two, without writing code.
- **Built-in checkout and payments.** Shopify Payments and many payment methods are available in one place.
- **Themes and apps.** A large theme store and app store cover most needs, from design to email marketing to shipping.
- **Room to grow.** The same platform serves a one-person home business and large international brands.

Shopify is not the only option. WooCommerce (WordPress), BigCommerce, Wix and others are alternatives. Learning Shopify well is valuable because it is widely used by merchants and by agencies, which means demand for skilled people is strong.

1.3 How a Shopify store works

Every Shopify store has two sides. The **storefront** is what customers see. The **admin** is where you, the merchant, manage products, orders, customers and settings. Figure 1.1 shows the path an order takes from first visit to a happy customer.



Storefront (customer side) on the left, admin and fulfilment in the middle, repeat customers on the right

Figure 1.1: The life of one order in a Shopify store

1.4 Core vocabulary

Learn these terms now. You will see every one of them again.

Term	Plain meaning
Storefront	The public website customers browse and buy from
Admin	The back office where you manage the store
Theme	The design template that controls how the storefront looks
App	An add-on from the Shopify App Store that adds a feature
Product / variant	A product is the item; a variant is a version of it, such as a specific size and colour
SKU	Stock Keeping Unit, your internal code for a variant
Collection	A group of products, such as "Summer dresses"
Fulfilment	Picking, packing and shipping an order
Sessions	Visits to your store
Conversion rate (CVR)	Share of sessions that end in an order
AOV	Average order value: revenue divided by number of orders
CAC	Customer acquisition cost: marketing spend divided by new customers
LTV	Lifetime value: total profit a customer brings over time

1.5 How this course works

The course has fourteen chapters that follow the real life of a store: business foundations, setup, products, design, apps, payments, shipping, marketing, analytics, scaling, careers, and a capstone project. Each chapter ends with key takeaways and a practice task. You do not need prior coding knowledge. Chapter 6 introduces a little code so you can read what developers do, but you can skip it and still succeed as a store manager.

> **Practice task (30 minutes).** Visit five Shopify stores you already like. For each, write down: the first thing you see, how many clicks it takes to reach a product, whether the price is visible without scrolling, and what the checkout button says. You will use these notes in Chapters 6 and 8.

Key takeaways

- E-commerce is buying and selling online; a Shopify store is your own branded version of it.
- Shopify runs hosting, security and checkout so you can focus on the business.
- Every store has a storefront (customer side) and an admin (merchant side).
- Learn the core vocabulary early; it makes every later chapter easier.

CHAPTER 2

E-commerce Business Foundations

> Most stores fail for business reasons, not technical ones. Products nobody wants, prices that do not cover costs, and no plan for getting customers. This chapter helps you choose a sensible model, test demand, and check the numbers before you spend money.

2.1 Choosing a business model

There is no single best model. Each one trades off startup cost, control over the product, margin and effort.

Model	How it works	Startup cost	Margin	Main risk
Dropshipping	A supplier ships directly to the customer; you never hold stock	Low	Low to medium	Slow shipping, thin margins, copycat competition
Print on demand	You design; a partner prints and ships each item	Low	Medium	Quality control and high cost per item
Own brand (private label)	You source a product from a manufacturer and sell it under your name	Medium to high	Good	Stock risk, minimum order quantities, brand building
Retail resale	You buy from wholesalers or brands and resell	Medium	Low to medium	Authorisation rules, price pressure
Digital products	Templates, courses, software, printables	Very low	Very high	Hard to stand out; piracy
Subscriptions	Customers pay regularly for a product or box	Medium	Good	Churn; needs a subscription app

For a first store, a narrow own-brand or print-on-demand range is often the most practical. Dropshipping is possible, but check delivery times carefully; customers who wait four weeks for an order rarely return.

2.2 Market research: proving there is demand

An idea is not a market. Before you buy stock or build a store, look for evidence that people already search for, talk about, and pay for something like your product.

1. **Search demand.** Use Google Trends to compare search interest over twelve months. Look for steady or rising interest, not a single spike.
2. **Competitor check.** Search the product on Google, Amazon, Daraz or other marketplaces. Many competitors can mean demand, but you need a difference you can explain.
3. **Ad library.** Meta's Ad Library shows active ads for any Page. Ads that have run for months are usually profitable.
4. **Customer language.** Read reviews of competitors and questions on Reddit, Facebook groups and YouTube comments. Copy the words customers use; they become your headlines.
5. **Small test.** Before committing to stock, test with a landing page, a pre-order button or a small ad budget and count real clicks and sign-ups.

Niche scorecard

Score each idea from 1 (weak) to 5 (strong). Choose ideas with a total of 30 or more, and be honest.

Criterion	What to ask
Demand	Are people searching for and buying this now?
Margin	Can you sell at a price that leaves at least 30 percent gross margin after product costs?
Size and weight	Is it light and small enough to ship cheaply?
Repeat purchase	Will customers need it again, or buy related items?
Differentiation	Can you add a clear reason to buy from you: design, bundle, story, service?
Your knowledge	Do you understand the customer and the product?

2.3 Unit economics: the numbers behind every sale

Unit economics is the cost of making and delivering one sale. If it does not work for one order, scaling will only lose money faster. Figure 2.1 shows a typical breakdown of a 100-unit sale price.

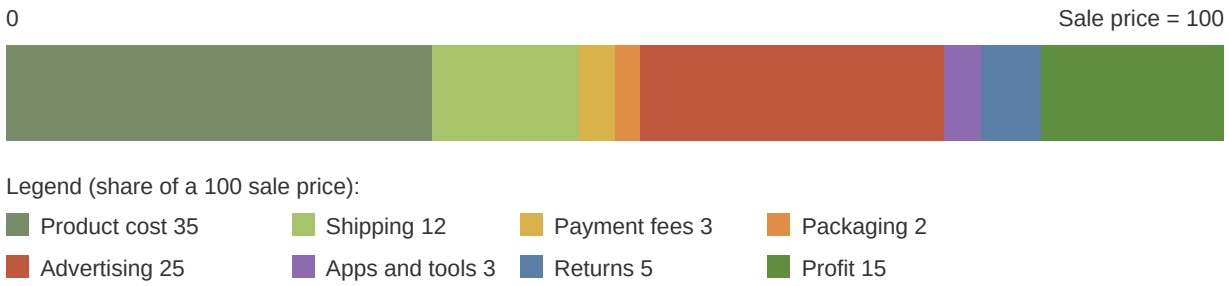


Figure 2.1: Where a 100 sale price goes in a typical small store (illustrative numbers)

The core formulas are:

- **Gross margin** = (Price minus product cost) divided by Price.
- **Contribution per order** = Price minus all variable costs (product, shipping, payment fees, packaging, returns, and the ad cost per order).
- **Break-even ROAS** = 1 divided by contribution margin percentage. If your contribution margin before ads is 40 percent, you need a return on ad spend above 2.5 just to break even on ads.

> **Worked example.** A phone case sells for 25. Product cost 6, shipping 3, payment fees about 0.9 (roughly 3.5 percent), packaging 0.5. Before ads you keep 25 minus 10.4 = 14.6 per order, a contribution margin of about 58 percent. Break-even ROAS is 1 divided by 0.58, about 1.7. Anything above that is profitable on ads alone. Now do the same calculation for your own niche before you buy stock.

2.4 Legal and administrative basics

Rules differ by country, state and product, so treat this section as a checklist to take to a local accountant or lawyer, not as legal advice.

- **Business registration.** Decide whether to operate as a sole trader, partnership or registered company. Registration affects liability, tax and how banks treat you.

- **Business bank account.** Keep business money separate. It makes bookkeeping and tax much easier.
- **Tax registration.** Find out when you must register for sales tax, VAT, GST or equivalent, and whether it applies to online sales into other regions.
- **Product compliance.** Some products need safety testing, labels or certificates, especially toys, cosmetics, electronics and food.
- **Intellectual property.** Do not use brand names, logos or copyrighted images you do not own. Check trademarks before you name your store.
- **Consumer law.** Most countries require clear pricing, honest descriptions, a cooling-off or return right in some cases, and secure handling of customer data.

2.5 Your first business plan on one page

Write a one-page plan with these headings: the customer (who, what problem, where they shop); the offer (product, price, why you); the numbers (price, unit cost, target conversion rate, monthly ad budget, break-even orders); the channels (how you will find customers in the first 90 days); the risks (supplier delay, returns, a competitor cutting prices) and how you will handle each; and the budget (how much you can lose without damage).

Key takeaways

- Choose a model that fits your budget and tolerance for stock risk; own-brand or print-on-demand suit many beginners.
- Prove demand with search data, competitor research and a small test before you commit money.
- Calculate unit economics first. A sale that loses money cannot be fixed with volume.
- Handle legal and tax basics early, with local professional advice.

CHAPTER 3

Setting Up Your Shopify Store

> In this chapter you will create a store, configure the settings that every merchant needs, and reach the point where a test order can go through. Work through the steps in order; several later settings depend on earlier ones.

3.1 Creating your account

Go to shopify.com and start a free trial. You will be asked for an email address, a store name and some basic business details. The store name is shown to customers, so choose something short, easy to spell and available as a domain name. Shopify offers several plans (Starter, Basic, Grow, Advanced and Plus). For a beginner the Basic plan is usually enough. Plan prices, features and transaction fees change from time to time, so always check the current pricing page before you decide.

3.2 Choosing and connecting a domain

Your store gets a free address ending in myshopify.com. For a real brand you want your own domain, such as yourbrand.com. You can buy a domain through Shopify or through another registrar and connect it to your store. Shopify provides and renews the SSL certificate that makes your site secure (the padlock in the browser). Pick a domain that matches your brand name and avoid hyphens and numbers where possible.

3.3 Store details and general settings

Open **Settings > Store details** and fill in your legal business name, address, contact email and phone number. Customers and payment providers check this information. Then open **Settings > General** to confirm:

- **Store currency**: the currency customers see and that you are paid in. Changing it later can affect old orders, so decide carefully.
- **Time zone and units**: used for reports, order times and product weights.
- **Customer accounts**: decide whether customers must log in to check out or whether guest checkout is allowed. Guest checkout usually converts better.

3.4 The setup checklist

Shopify shows a setup guide on your home page. Figure 3.1 shows the order that works best for a new store.

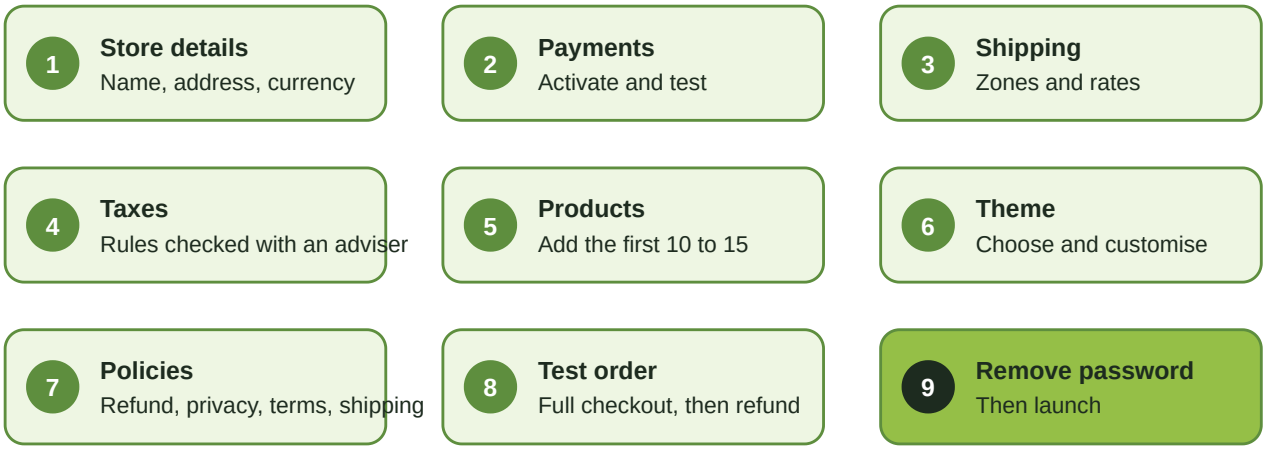


Figure 3.1: Setup checklist in the recommended order

3.5 Payments

Go to **Settings > Payments**. The most common route is Shopify Payments, which lets customers pay by major cards and wallets and pays the money into your bank account. Shopify Payments availability depends on your country. If it is not available, you can use a third-party gateway. Complete identity and bank verification, and enable the payment methods your customers expect in your market. Finish verification before launch, because delays here stop payouts.

3.6 Shipping and delivery zones

Go to **Settings > Shipping and delivery**. Create a shipping zone for each region you serve, then add rates. Common rate types are a flat fee, a rate based on weight, a rate based on order price, and free shipping above a threshold. A simple start is one domestic zone with two rates: standard shipping at a flat fee and free shipping above a threshold that is a little higher than your average order value. Chapter 9 covers shipping in depth.

3.7 Taxes

Go to **Settings > Taxes and duties**. Shopify can collect tax automatically in some regions, or you can set your own rates. Enter your tax-inclusive or tax-exclusive pricing preference. Check with your accountant which tax applies to your products, whether prices should include tax, and when you must register. Do not guess here; tax mistakes are costly and hard to unwind.

3.8 Policies and legal pages

Go to **Settings > Policies**. Shopify can generate a refund policy, privacy policy, terms of service, shipping policy and contact information page. These templates are a starting point. Read them, edit them to match what you actually do (for example, your return window and who pays return postage), and have a professional review them before you launch in a regulated market. Policies are shown at checkout and in your footer, and many payment providers require them to be live.

3.9 Staff accounts

If you work with a partner or assistant, invite them under **Settings > Users and permissions**. Give each person the lowest access they need. A customer-service assistant does not need access to payouts or billing. Use

strong passwords and turn on two-factor authentication for every account with admin rights.

3.10 Testing before launch

Before you remove the password page, place a full test order on the storefront. Use Shopify's test payment method for development stores, or a real low-value order that you refund. Check that: the confirmation email arrives, the order appears in the admin, the tax and shipping amounts are right on mobile and desktop, and the refund works. Then open **Online Store > Preferences** and remove the password protection when you are ready.

Common mistake. Launching with incomplete policies, untested payments or wrong shipping rates. Customers will find these problems in minutes and leave, and payment providers may pause your account. Finish the checklist first, then launch.

Key takeaways

- Choose a plan, a short memorable store name and a domain you can use for years.
- Complete store details, currency, payments, shipping, taxes and policies before launch.
- Place a full test order and refund it before you remove the password page.
- Give team members only the permissions they need.

Practice task. Create a development or trial store. Complete steps 1 to 4 of the checklist in Figure 3.1 and write down anything you could not finish and why. Keep the notes; they become your launch checklist in the capstone (Chapter 14).

CHAPTER 4

Navigating the Shopify Admin

> The admin is your control room. Merchants who know it well can find an order in seconds, spot a problem before a customer complains, and make changes without calling support. This chapter walks through the main areas and builds a daily routine.

4.1 The layout

The left sidebar holds the main sections. The top bar has search, notifications and your store switcher. Figure 4.1 is a simplified sketch; the exact labels and order can change as Shopify updates the admin, but the logic stays the same.

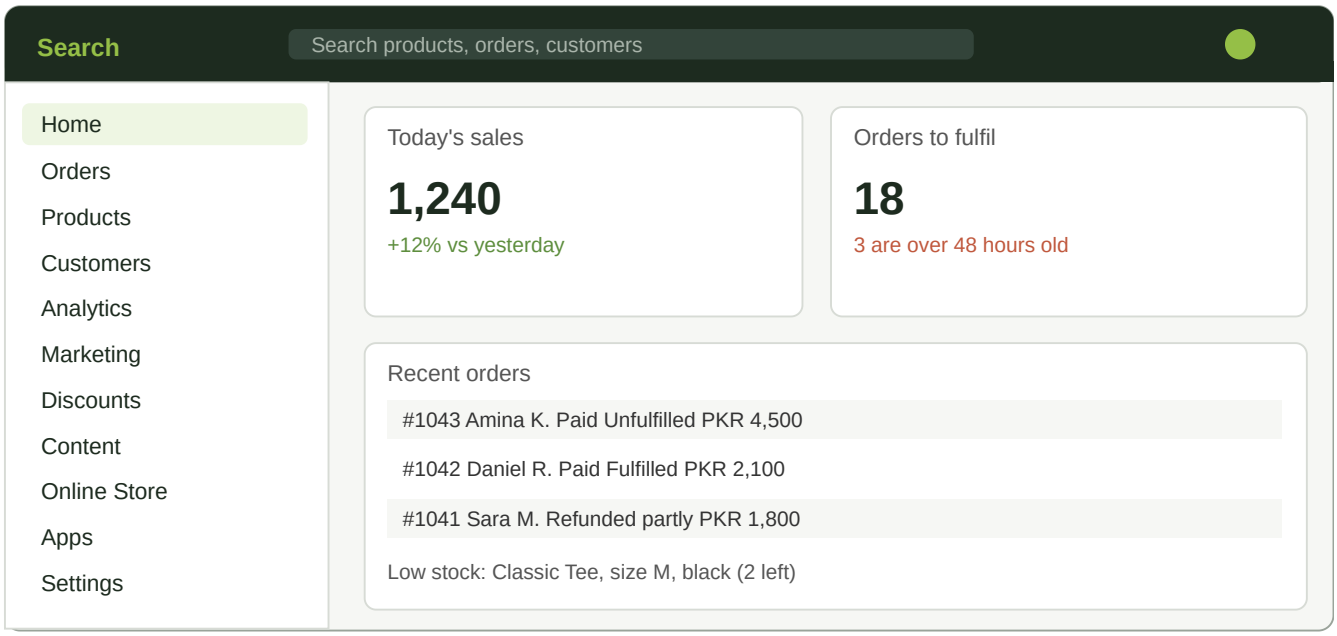


Figure 4.1: Simplified admin layout (illustrative; labels may differ slightly in your version)

4.2 Orders: the most important screen

Orders go through two separate statuses that beginners often confuse:

- **Payment status**: Paid, Pending, Refunded or Partially refunded.
- **Fulfilment status**: Unfulfilled, Fulfilled or Partially fulfilled.

A paid, unfulfilled order is your work queue. Use the filters to show only those orders, and sort by oldest first. Tags help you group orders, for example *gift*, *wholesale* or *check address*. When you open an order, you can see the customer, items, shipping address, payment details, timeline and notes. Add an internal note whenever you contact a customer about an order, so a colleague can see the history.

4.3 Customers and segments

Each customer record stores orders, addresses, marketing consent and notes. Segments group customers by rules, for example "bought more than twice in 90 days" or "spent over a set amount". Segments are useful for

email campaigns and for judging loyalty. Respect consent: only email people who agreed to marketing messages, and honour unsubscribe requests immediately.

4.4 Products, collections and discounts

The Products section is covered in Chapter 5, and the Discounts section in Chapter 8. In brief: discount codes are typed by the customer at checkout; automatic discounts apply when the cart meets conditions; and you can set limits on use, minimum purchase, dates and eligible products. Test every discount in a private browser window before you announce it.

4.5 Settings you will use often

Setting	What it controls
Store details	Business name, address, contact information shown to customers
Payments	Payment providers, payment methods, payouts
Shipping and delivery	Zones, rates, pickup locations, packing slips
Taxes and duties	Tax collection, rates, duties for international orders
Checkout	Customer information requirements, marketing opt-in, order tips
Notifications	Emails sent to customers and staff (order confirmation, shipping, refunds)
Policies	Refund, privacy, terms and shipping policies
Markets	Countries, currencies and languages you sell in (Chapter 12)
Users and permissions	Staff accounts and what each can access

4.6 The Shopify mobile app

The Shopify mobile app lets you check orders, reply to customers, view sales and receive alerts while away from your desk. Use it for monitoring, but do bulk changes such as product imports and theme edits on a computer, where you can see more detail.

4.7 A daily routine

1. **Morning (15 minutes):** check sales and sessions on the home page, then open unfulfilled orders and clear anything paid more than 24 hours ago.
2. **Midday (10 minutes):** answer customer messages, check for low-stock alerts, and confirm that today's shipments left.
3. **Evening (10 minutes):** check failed payments, refund requests and any reviews that need a reply.
4. **Weekly (45 minutes):** review the Analytics reports, top products, discount performance and shipping costs (Chapter 11).

> **Common mistake.** Treating "Paid" as "done". A paid order that is not packed and shipped is a customer waiting for a parcel. Your fulfilment queue is more important than your sales dashboard.

Key takeaways

- Learn the sidebar sections and where each setting lives.
- Track payment status and fulfilment status separately.
- Use filters, tags and notes to run orders without losing track.
- Build a short daily routine; consistency beats occasional long sessions.

Practice task. In a development store, create three test orders, mark one as fulfilled, refund part of one, and add a tag and an internal note to each. Then use the filters to show only unfulfilled orders.

CHAPTER 5

Products, Collections and Inventory

> Your product pages do most of the selling. Clear data, good photos and honest descriptions turn visitors into buyers. This chapter explains how Shopify structures products, how to write and photograph them, and how to keep stock accurate.

5.1 Anatomy of a product

A product in Shopify has a title, description, media (images and video), pricing, inventory, shipping details, organisation fields and search-engine fields. Here are the fields that matter most:

Field	Purpose and advice
Title	Clear and specific, for example "Classic Cotton T-shirt, Relaxed Fit". Avoid keyword stuffing.
Description	Benefits first, then features, materials, sizing and care. Chapter 5.4 gives a template.
Price and compare-at price	Price is what customers pay. Compare-at price shows a crossed-out original price. Use it only when the reference price was real.
SKU and barcode	Your internal codes. Keep them unique; they link stock to orders and to suppliers.
Options and variants	Size, colour, material and so on. Each combination becomes a variant with its own price, stock and SKU.
Inventory	Track quantity per location. Turn off tracking only for items you truly never run out of.
Weight	Needed for accurate shipping rates. Enter the packed weight if you can.
Product type, vendor, tags	Used for filtering, collections, automation and reports.
Metafields	Extra custom data, such as fabric care codes or size charts, shown on the storefront when a theme supports them.
URL handle and SEO fields	The page address and the title and description shown in Google. Chapter 10 covers SEO.

5.2 Options and variants

Use variants when a customer chooses between versions of the same product. Use separate products when the item is genuinely different, such as a T-shirt and a hoodie. Figure 5.1 shows the structure for a T-shirt sold in three sizes and two colours.



Figure 5.1: One product, two options, six variants (3 sizes x 2 colours), each with its own SKU and stock

Common mistake. Creating a separate product for every colour. It splits reviews, weakens search rankings and makes the catalogue harder to manage. Use colour and size variants instead.

5.3 Collections

Collections group products for navigation and merchandising. There are two types:

- **Manual collections** contain products you add by hand. Use them for hand-picked lists such as "Editor's picks".
- **Automated (smart) collections** add products that match rules, such as product type equals "Hoodie", or tag equals "new-arrival". Use them for categories that must stay current.

Keep your navigation to five or six top-level collections. Too many choices make shoppers stop and think, and thinking reduces purchases.

5.4 Writing descriptions that sell

Use this structure for every product description:

1. **Headline benefit** in one line: what the product does for the customer.
2. **Short paragraph** that describes the situation the customer is in and how the product helps.
3. **Bullet points** with specifications: material, dimensions, weight, care, origin.
4. **Sizing help**: a size chart and a sentence on fit (for example, "Runs slightly large; size down for a fitted look").
5. **Reassurance**: delivery time, return policy link, warranty if any.

Example. Weak: "Nice blue water bottle, 750 ml." Better: "Stay hydrated all day without the plastic taste. This 750 ml stainless steel bottle keeps drinks cold for 24 hours and hot for 12. Leak-proof lid, fits most car cup holders. Dishwasher safe."

5.5 Product photography

Photos are the strongest sales tool you have, and they cost less than most people expect. You need:

- At least one clean studio shot on a plain background, with consistent lighting and the product filling about 80 percent of the frame.
- Shots of the product in use, on a person or in a real setting.
- Detail close-ups: texture, stitching, buttons, labels.

- Scale reference: the product beside a common object, or a size-on-model shot with the model's height stated.
- A short video if possible. Customers watch video longer and it often lifts conversion.

Use a square or 4:5 ratio, export at a sensible size (around 2000 pixels on the long side, compressed to a few hundred kilobytes), and name files descriptively, such as *classic-tee-black-front.jpg*. Smaller files make the store faster, which matters for both search rankings and sales.

5.6 Inventory and stock control

Inventory is tracked per location. If you have one warehouse and a home office, add both as locations and assign stock to the place it is stored. Set a low-stock threshold so Shopify warns you before you sell out. Use the CSV import and export tools for bulk changes: export your products, edit in a spreadsheet, and import again. Always back up the export before a large import.

Overselling happens when stock is wrong. Count your physical stock at least once a month, reconcile it with the admin, and record every return that goes back on the shelf.

5.7 Pricing basics

Price from your unit economics (Chapter 2), not from what a competitor charges. Then test: prices ending in 9 or 99 often perform well in many markets, but test with your own customers. Use compare-at prices honestly. If you show "was 3,000, now 2,000", the 3,000 must have been a real recent price. False discounts damage trust and can breach consumer law.

Key takeaways

- Fill in every product field that customers, search engines or your reports use.
- Use variants for sizes and colours; use separate products only for different items.
- Write benefit-led descriptions with specs, sizing and reassurance.
- Photograph the product clearly, in use and in detail; compress images.
- Keep stock accurate per location and count physically each month.

Practice task. Create one product with two options and at least three variants. Write a description using the five-part structure, add three photos (or three placeholder images), set a low-stock threshold, and export your product list as a CSV file.

CHAPTER 6

Store Design with Themes

> Design builds trust in seconds. A clean, fast, easy-to-navigate store makes customers feel safe buying from you. This chapter covers choosing a theme, using the theme editor, applying simple design principles, and a short introduction to the code behind a theme, so that you can talk to developers in their language.

6.1 Choosing a theme

Shopify themes are templates that control layout, typography and colour. You can use free or paid themes from the Shopify Theme Store. Dawn is Shopify's free, modern reference theme and a very good starting point. When you compare themes, check:

- **Speed.** Test the demo on mobile with Google PageSpeed Insights. Heavy themes with many animations can slow your store.
- **Mobile layout.** Most sales now happen on phones. Open the demo on a small screen and check the menu, product page and checkout button.
- **Sections.** Modern themes are built from sections you can add, remove and reorder without code. Check that the sections you need exist.
- **Support and updates.** Look at the developer's update history and documentation.
- **Fit.** The demo should look like the customer you want to reach. A luxury jewellery theme will not suit a budget tool shop.

6.2 The theme editor

Go to **Online Store > Themes > Customize**. The editor shows a live preview on the left and settings on the right. The important ideas are:

- **Templates** are page types: home page, product, collection, cart, search, blog, page and 404. Each template can have different sections.
- **Sections** are blocks of content such as a hero banner, product grid, testimonials or FAQ. You add, reorder and configure them.
- **Blocks** are items inside a section, such as one slide in a slider or one review card.
- **Header and footer** hold your logo, navigation menus, announcement bar and legal links. Menus are created under **Navigation**.
- **Theme settings** control global items: fonts, colours, buttons, spacing and icons.

Always click **Duplicate** on the live theme before you experiment. A copy lets you edit safely while customers keep seeing the original.

6.3 Design principles that convert

You do not need to be a designer to make good choices. Follow these principles:

1. **Clear hierarchy.** The eye should go first to the headline, then to the product or offer, then to the button. Use size, weight and spacing to show this order.

2. **One main action per screen.** On a product page the main action is "Add to cart". Make it the most visible button.
3. **Whitespace.** Empty space makes premium products look premium and helps busy shoppers read.
4. **Contrast and readability.** Dark text on a light background, at least 16 pixels for body text on mobile, and enough contrast for people with low vision.
5. **Consistency.** Use two fonts at most, a palette of four or five colours, and the same button style throughout.
6. **Trust signals.** Show reviews, delivery times, return policy and secure payment logos close to the buy button.

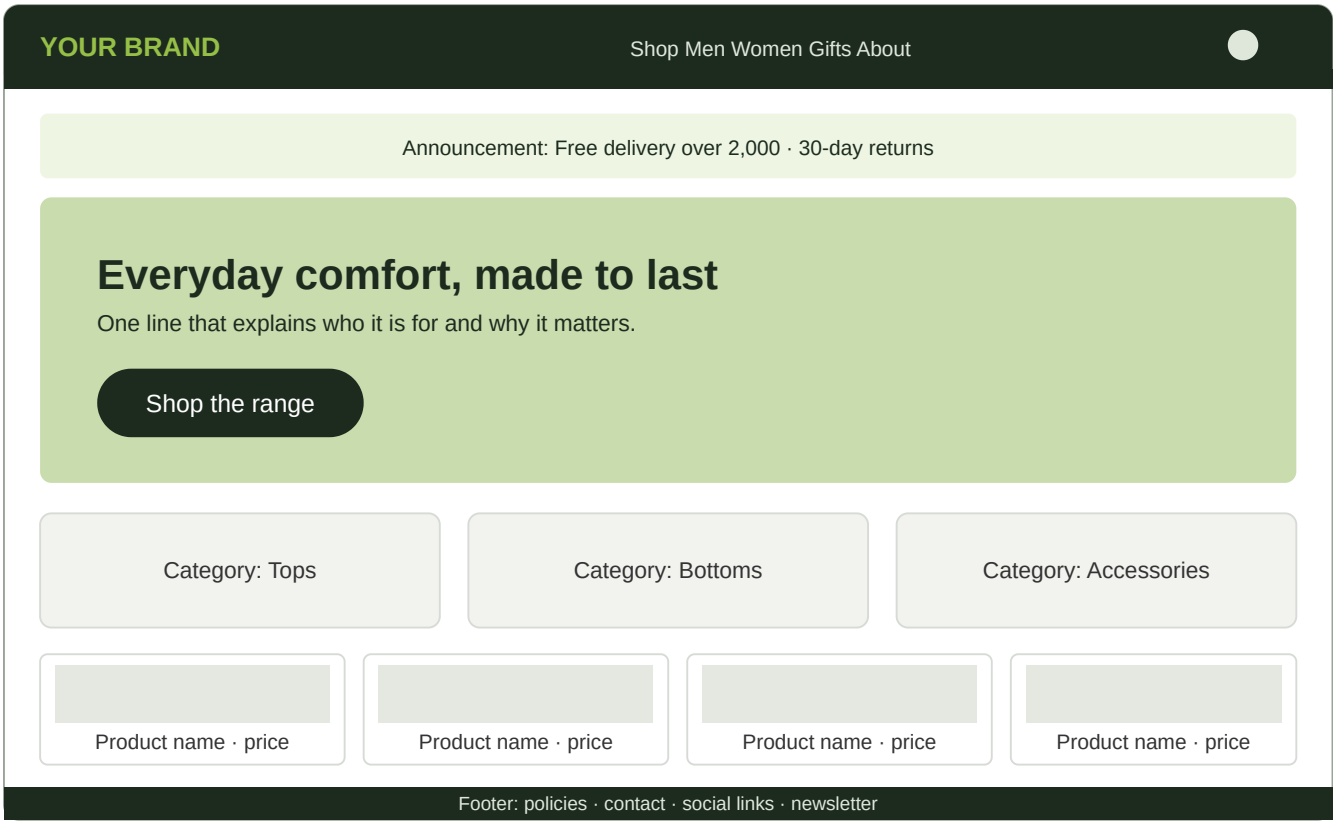


Figure 6.1: Home page wireframe showing hierarchy: announcement, hero, categories, products, footer

6.4 Speed and mobile performance

Speed affects both search ranking and conversion. Aim for pages that load their main content within about two to three seconds on a typical mobile connection. The main levers are:

- Upload images at the size they display, not the size they were taken. Use the theme's image settings and avoid giant hero images.
- Install fewer apps. Every app can add scripts to every page. Remove any app you do not use.
- Limit custom fonts to two families and only the weights you use.
- Use video sparingly, and never autoplay with sound.
- Test on a real phone over mobile data, not only on your office Wi-Fi.

6.5 Understanding a theme's code

You do not need to write code to run a store, but understanding the basics helps you brief developers, check changes and fix small issues. Shopify themes are built with **Liquid**, an open template language, mixed with HTML, CSS and JavaScript. Liquid shows data and controls what appears:

```
<h1>{{ product.title }}</h1>
<p>Price: {{ product.price | money }}</p>

{% if product.available %}
  <button>Add to cart</button>
{% else %}
  <p>Sold out</p>
{% endif %}

{% for image in product.images %}
  <img src="{{ image | image_url: width: 800 }}" alt="{{ image.alt }}">
{% endfor %}
```

The three kinds of tag are: `{{ ... }}` outputs a value, `{% ... %}` runs logic such as if-statements and loops, and `|` passes a value through a filter such as `money`.

A theme is a folder of files with a standard layout:

```
theme/
  assets/      CSS, JavaScript, images, fonts
  config/      settings_schema.json and settings_data.json (theme settings)
  layout/      theme.liquid (the outer HTML wrapper for every page)
  locales/     translation files (en.default.json and others)
  sections/    reusable sections that merchants can add and edit
  snippets/    small reusable pieces of Liquid (icons, buttons)
  templates/   page templates: index, product, collection, cart, page, 404 ...
```

Developers work on a theme locally with the Shopify CLI, using commands such as `shopify theme dev` to preview changes on a development store and `shopify theme pull` and `shopify theme push` to sync files. Use version control (Git) for any custom theme work so you can roll back a bad change.

> **Common mistake.** Editing the live theme's code directly. A single syntax error can take the whole store down. Duplicate the theme, test the copy on a preview link, then publish.

Key takeaways

- Choose a theme for speed, mobile layout, sections and fit with your brand. Start from Dawn if unsure.
- Use templates, sections and blocks in the theme editor to build pages without code.
- Design for hierarchy, one main action, whitespace, readability and trust.
- Keep the store fast: few apps, sized images, limited fonts.
- Know Liquid's basic syntax and the theme folder structure so you can work with developers.

> **Practice task.** Duplicate your theme. Build a home page with five sections: announcement bar, hero banner, featured collection, reviews and footer. Check it on a 375-pixel-wide mobile preview. Write down three changes you would make to improve clarity.

CHAPTER 7

Apps, Integrations and Customisation

> Apps extend your store with features Shopify does not include out of the box: reviews, email tools, subscriptions, accounting connections and more. Used well, they save hours. Used carelessly, they slow the store, clash with each other and leak money every month. This chapter shows you how to choose, manage and automate apps wisely.

7.1 What apps do

Apps are software from Shopify or independent developers that connect to your store through Shopify's APIs. They can add a page, a checkout feature, a background process or an integration with an outside system. You find them in the Shopify App Store, and you install them from the admin with one click. Most apps offer a free plan or a free trial, then charge a monthly fee.



Figure 7.1: Apps and integrations connect to the store through APIs, webhooks and automations

7.2 How to choose an app

Before installing an app, run through this checklist:

1. **Do you need it now?** If a manual process works for the next month, wait.
2. **Is there a built-in feature?** Shopify's own features (for example discounts, Shopify Email, or basic reports) are often enough.
3. **Reviews.** Read recent reviews, not just the average rating. Look for complaints about support, billing or broken features.
4. **Last update and developer.** Check when the app was last updated and whether the developer has a clear support route.
5. **Total cost.** Add the monthly fee, any per-order charges and the cost of the plan needed to unlock features.
6. **Speed impact.** Test your store speed before and after installing. Remove apps that add slow scripts for little benefit.
7. **Permissions.** Read what data the app requests. Install only apps that need data relevant to their job.

8. **Exit plan.** Find out how to remove the app and whether your data stays with you if you leave.

7.3 Common app categories

Category	Typical use	Beginner advice
Product reviews	Collect and show star ratings and photos	Install early; social proof lifts conversion
Email and SMS	Welcome flows, abandoned carts, newsletters	Start with the built-in email tools, then upgrade
Upselling and bundles	Add-ons, "frequently bought together", volume discounts	Test one at a time and measure AOV
Shipping and labels	Rate calculation, label printing, tracking pages	Choose one tool that matches your carriers
Accounting	Sync orders, refunds and fees to your books	Essential once you have regular sales
SEO	Meta tags, redirects, sitemaps, image alt text	Chapter 10 explains what you actually need
Subscriptions	Recurring orders	Check how it handles failed payments
Translation	Localised content for international markets	Needed for Chapter 12 markets

7.4 Managing your app stack

Keep a simple list of every app: what it does, its monthly cost, who owns it, when it was last reviewed and whether it is essential. Review the list every quarter. Typical waste includes two apps that do the same job, a trial that quietly became a paid plan, and an app from a campaign that ended months ago. Uninstall unused apps fully, because some leave code or scripts in the theme.

7.5 Automating with Shopify Flow

Shopify Flow is a built-in automation tool. Each workflow has a **trigger** (something that happens), optional **conditions** (checks), and **actions** (things that then happen). Flow saves time without a developer. Examples:

Trigger	Condition	Action
Order created	Order total is above 10,000	Add tag "high-value" and notify the owner
Customer's total spent changes	Total spent is above a threshold you set	Add tag "VIP" to the customer
Order paid	Shipping country is outside your zone	Add tag "international-review" for a manual check
Inventory level changes	Quantity falls below the threshold	Send a message to the supplier channel

Test every workflow on a development store first, and keep a note of what each one does. An automation that tags the wrong customers can mislead your marketing for months.

7.6 Custom apps and the developer path

If you have an unusual need, a developer can build a custom app. Shopify provides the Admin GraphQL API (to read and write store data), the Storefront API (to build custom shopping experiences), webhooks (to receive notifications when events happen) and the Dev Dashboard for managing app credentials. Shopify also supports

headless storefronts through its own React-based framework, Hydrogen. You do not need to know these tools to manage a store, but knowing they exist helps you plan larger projects and ask the right questions.

Common mistake. Installing five apps in the first week. Each one adds scripts, costs money and creates another login to manage. Start with the essentials and add only when a clear need appears.

Key takeaways

- Apps extend your store, but every app has a cost, a speed impact and a maintenance burden.
- Check reviews, updates, total cost, permissions and the exit route before you install.
- Review your app list quarterly and remove anything unused.
- Use Shopify Flow to automate repetitive tasks; test each workflow first.

Practice task. Make a table of the apps you would need for a store selling one product category. For each app, write the cost, the reason, and the built-in alternative. Cut the list to the three you would install on day one.

CHAPTER 8

Payments, Checkout, Taxes and Policies

Checkout is where money changes hands, and most lost sales happen here. This chapter explains how payments work, how to make checkout smooth and trustworthy, how to think about tax and fraud, and why your policies are part of your sales process.

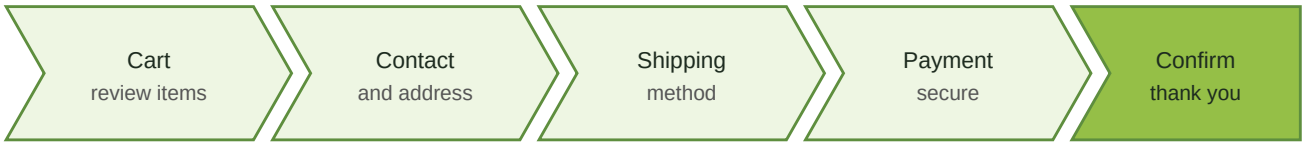
8.1 How payments work

When a customer pays, the money goes from the customer's bank or wallet, through a payment provider, to your bank account. The provider charges a fee and holds funds for a short period before paying out. Shopify offers Shopify Payments, which is built into the store, or you can connect third-party gateways. Each gateway has its own fees, supported countries and payout schedule. Compare them before choosing, and check the total cost including the fee on each transaction and any extra fee for not using Shopify Payments.

- **Payment methods** include cards, digital wallets, Shop Pay (Shopify's accelerated checkout), and local methods depending on the country. Offering the methods your customers already use increases conversion.
- **Payouts** are the transfers from the provider to your bank. Know the schedule so you can plan stock purchases.
- **Chargebacks and disputes** happen when a customer asks their bank to reverse a payment. Keep clear delivery evidence, respond to disputes on time and keep your order records tidy.

8.2 The checkout journey

Figure 8.1 shows the standard path. Every extra step, field or surprise cost is a point where people leave.



Fewer fields, visible total cost early, and trust signals at payment are the main levers

Figure 8.1: The checkout journey, with the points where most customers decide

8.3 Making checkout convert

- **Allow guest checkout** so people do not need an account to buy.
- **Show total cost early.** Surprise shipping or tax at the last step is one of the top reasons carts are abandoned. Show delivery cost on the product or cart page.
- **Ask only for what you need.** Each extra field costs conversions. Phone numbers are needed for some carriers; ask for them only if you use them.
- **Offer express payment.** Accelerated checkout buttons shorten the journey for returning customers.
- **Use trust signals near the payment step:** secure payment icons, clear return policy link, customer support contact.

- **Customise checkout carefully.** Shopify's checkout can be branded and extended through its checkout extensibility features. Keep changes minimal and test on mobile.

8.4 Abandoned carts

Many shoppers add items and leave. Shopify records abandoned checkouts and can send recovery emails. A typical recovery sequence has three emails: a reminder within a few hours, a message that addresses a likely objection (delivery, returns, sizing), and a final message with a clear reason to return, such as a limited offer you genuinely honour. Do not discount on the first reminder; you train customers to wait for discounts.

8.5 Taxes

Tax rules are complicated and vary by country, state and product. In outline, you need to know:

- Whether your prices include tax or tax is added at checkout.
- Which tax rate applies to each product and each destination.
- When you must register and begin collecting tax.
- Who pays import duties on international orders (you, or the customer at delivery). This is set in the Markets and duties settings (Chapter 12).

Shopify's tax settings can calculate and collect tax automatically in supported regions, and apps can help where Shopify's built-in options are not enough. Still, the responsibility for correct filing stays with you. Keep records of every order, and review tax settings with an accountant at least once a year and whenever you launch in a new country.

8.6 Policies that protect you and the customer

Clear policies reduce disputes and make customers feel safe. Each should be short, specific and easy to find.

Policy	What it must say
Refund and return	How long customers have to return items, the condition required, who pays return shipping, how refunds are paid, and any exceptions (for example, personalised items)
Shipping	Where you ship, typical delivery times, cost basis, what happens if an order is delayed or lost
Privacy	What personal data you collect, why, who receives it (for example, carriers and payment providers), and how customers can access or delete it
Terms of service	Rules for using the store, pricing and error corrections, governing law
Contact information	Business name, address, email and phone, and how fast you reply

Your return policy must match what you actually do. A policy that promises a 30-day return and then refuses after 14 days is worse than having no policy at all.

8.7 Fraud and risk

Fraud appears as stolen cards, false refund claims and fake addresses. Shopify provides automated fraud analysis that flags risky orders. Review flagged orders manually, especially high-value orders, first orders from unfamiliar locations and orders where the shipping address differs sharply from the billing address. Never ship a

flagged order without checking. Also be cautious with very large first orders, unusual quantities and rush shipping requests from new accounts.

Common mistake. Hiding shipping or tax costs until the final step. Customers who feel tricked leave, and some write negative reviews. Show the true total early, even if it is less attractive than a low product price.

Key takeaways

- Compare payment providers on total cost, payouts and supported methods.
- Make checkout short, transparent and fast on mobile; allow guest checkout.
- Use abandoned-cart emails that help customers rather than rushing them into discounts.
- Check tax rules with a professional; keep order records.
- Write clear, honest policies and review flagged orders before shipping.

Practice task. Go through your own checkout on a phone as if you were a customer. Count the steps and fields, note where the total cost first appears, and list three changes that would reduce friction without removing anything you legally need.

CHAPTER 9

Shipping, Fulfilment and Returns

Customers judge your store by the parcel that arrives at their door. Fast, accurate, well-packed delivery builds repeat business; late or damaged orders create refunds and bad reviews. This chapter covers shipping rates, fulfilment options, the daily dispatch process and handling returns.

9.1 Shipping rates

Shipping costs can destroy margin if they are set without thought. Choose a model that fits your product:

- **Flat rate**: one fee for everything. Simple, good for light, uniform products.
- **Weight-based**: the fee rises with the parcel's weight. Good when weights vary widely.
- **Price-based**: the fee depends on the order total. Useful for free-shipping thresholds.
- **Carrier-calculated**: live rates from carriers, shown at checkout. Accurate but needs setup and can confuse customers.
- **Free shipping above a threshold**: a strong conversion tool. Set the threshold slightly above your average order value so customers add one more item.
- **Local pickup**: lets customers collect from you or a partner location, which can cut costs.

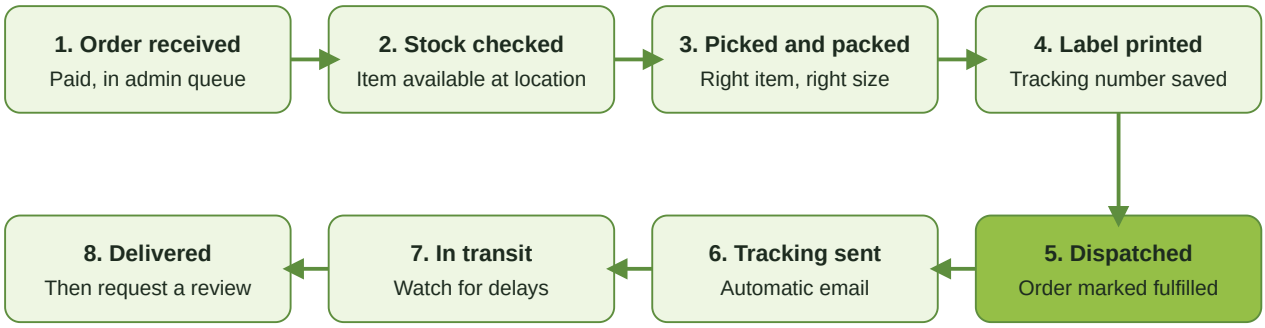
Example. Average order value is 1,800. Set free shipping at 2,000. Customers who are 200 short often add a sock pair or a second item, raising average order value while you still cover your shipping costs.

9.2 Fulfilment models

Model	How it works	Best for	Watch out for
Self-fulfilment	You store, pack and ship from home or a small unit	Start-ups with low volume	Your time becomes the bottleneck
Third-party logistics (3PL)	A warehouse stores and ships for you, integrated with your store	Growing stores with steady orders	Minimum fees, contract length, returns handling
Dropshipping supplier	The supplier ships directly to the customer	Testing products without stock	Stock accuracy, long delivery times, branding on the parcel
Print on demand	The partner prints and ships each item when ordered	Designs, merchandise	Quality varies; slower production

9.3 The fulfilment process

Figure 9.1 shows a reliable dispatch routine. Whatever your model, every order should pass through the same steps.



Run this routine at the same time every day; the cut-off time for same-day dispatch should be published.

Figure 9.1: The fulfilment routine, from paid order to delivered and reviewed

9.4 Packing and the unboxing experience

Good packing protects the product, reduces returns and creates a memorable first experience. Use boxes sized to the product, not oversized boxes filled with air, which cost more to ship. Include a packing slip, a thank-you note, care instructions and a clear returns route. Check every order against the slip before sealing the box. Photograph high-value or fragile orders as evidence in case of transit damage.

9.5 Tracking and communication

Turn on shipping confirmation and delivery update emails in **Settings > Notifications**. Include the tracking link and a realistic delivery window. When a parcel is delayed, contact the customer before they ask. Proactive updates prevent most "where is my order" tickets.

9.6 Returns and refunds

Returns are a cost of doing business in e-commerce. Plan for them rather than being surprised. A good returns process has five parts:

1. **A clear policy** (Chapter 8.6) that customers can read before buying.
2. **A simple request route**, such as a form or email with the order number.
3. **An approval step** to check the reason and condition of the item.
4. **A returns label or instructions**, with a tracked route for high-value items.
5. **A refund or exchange** issued promptly, plus restocking if the item is resaleable.

Track return reasons. If "wrong size" is the top reason, improve size guides. If "not as described" is high, improve photos and descriptions. Returns data is one of the best free sources of product improvement ideas.

> **Common mistake.** Refunding customers without tracking the reason. You then keep paying the cost of the same problem without learning anything. Log every return reason, even if you only look at the list monthly.

Key takeaways

- Choose a shipping rate model that protects your margin; use free-shipping thresholds to lift order value.
- Pick a fulfilment model that matches your volume and time, and grow into 3PL when the work demands it.
- Run a fixed dispatch routine every day, and send tracking automatically.
- Design a simple, fair returns process and learn from return reasons.

Practice task. Build a shipping table for a product that weighs 300 grams. Include a flat rate, a free-shipping threshold and a note on who pays returns. Calculate the margin on one order after shipping, packaging and returns cost.

CHAPTER 10

Marketing Your Store

> A beautiful store with no visitors earns nothing. Marketing is how strangers learn about your brand, trust it enough to buy, and return. This chapter explains the marketing funnel, the channels that matter for a Shopify store, how to start paid ads safely, and how to plan a year of promotions.

10.1 The marketing funnel

Customers move through stages. Each stage needs different messages and different measurements. Figure 10.1 shows the four stages and typical channels.



Figure 10.1: The four stages of the marketing funnel, with channels that serve each

Beginners often pour all their budget into the top of the funnel and ignore loyalty. Most profit in e-commerce comes from repeat customers, because acquiring a new customer is far more expensive than selling again to an existing one.

10.2 Search engine optimisation (SEO)

SEO brings free, ongoing traffic from Google. For a Shopify store, the basics are:

- **Product and collection titles** that describe what the customer searches for, such as "Stainless Steel Water Bottle 750 ml".
- **Meta titles and descriptions** written for people, not robots: clear, specific, under about 60 and 155 characters respectively.
- **Unique product descriptions**, not copied supplier text. Duplicate content is a common problem for stores that sell many similar items.
- **Image alt text** describing each picture, which helps accessibility and image search.
- **Fast pages and mobile-friendly design** (Chapter 6).
- **A blog or guide section** that answers real questions, for example "How to choose the right water bottle size". Publish consistently and link to relevant products.

- **Redirects** when you delete or rename a page, so old links do not lead to error pages.

SEO takes months. Measure progress in Google Search Console (free) and track organic sessions in your analytics.

10.3 Social media and content

Short-form video is the most powerful organic channel for many product categories. Platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, YouTube Shorts and Pinterest reward useful, entertaining or surprising content. Good formats for product stores include:

- **Demonstrations:** the product solving a problem in 15 to 30 seconds.
- **Before and after** results, shown honestly.
- **Behind the scenes:** packing orders, sourcing trips, design process.
- **User-generated content:** real customers using the product, with permission.
- **Answers to common questions**: sizing, care, durability.

Hook the viewer in the first three seconds with a question, a result or a surprising fact. Post consistently, reply to comments, and use the platform's own features rather than just reposting elsewhere.

10.4 Email and SMS

Email is the most profitable channel for many stores because you own the list. Build these automated flows first:

1. **Welcome series** (three to four emails): your story, best sellers, reviews, and a first-order incentive if you can afford it.
2. **Abandoned cart** (Chapter 8.4).
3. **Post-purchase**: order confirmation, shipping update, care tips, review request, then a cross-sell after the product is likely to be used up.
4. **Win-back**: for customers who have not bought in 90 to 120 days.

Use Shopify Email or an email app to build these flows. SMS can be powerful for time-sensitive messages, but you must get clear consent and follow local rules about marketing texts.

10.5 Paid advertising

Paid ads give fast results but cost money every day. The main platforms are Meta (Facebook and Instagram), Google (Search and Shopping), TikTok, Pinterest and YouTube. Start small and learn:

1. **Set a test budget** you can afford to lose completely. Decide the maximum you will spend before you judge results.
2. **Make several creatives**: different hooks, formats and product angles. Creative quality is the biggest driver of results on social platforms.
3. **Use the structure**: campaign (objective), ad set (audience and budget), ad (creative and copy). Keep one clear goal per campaign.
4. **Track properly**: install the platform pixel or connect the official Shopify channel app, and check that purchases are recorded correctly.
5. **Judge by return on ad spend (ROAS)** against your break-even figure from Chapter 2, not by clicks alone.
6. **Pause losers and scale winners slowly**. Increasing budget by large jumps often resets learning and hurts results.

Worked example. You spend 1,000 on ads and receive 3,500 in sales from them. ROAS is 3.5. If your contribution margin before ads is 40 percent, your gross profit from those sales is 1,400, which is more than the 1,000 spent, so the campaign made a profit of 400 before overheads. Your break-even ROAS is 1 divided by 0.40, which is 2.5.

10.6 Influencers, affiliates and partnerships

Creators can introduce your product to an audience that already trusts them. Choose creators whose audience matches your customer, check their engagement rather than follower count, and agree on clear deliverables, usage rights and a tracked discount code or link. Affiliate programmes pay a commission on sales and carry less upfront risk, but they attract opportunists unless you set terms carefully.

10.7 Planning promotions across the year

Build a yearly calendar of moments that matter to your customers: seasonal holidays, religious festivals, back-to-school, national days, sales events, and your own anniversary. Plan content and stock six to eight weeks ahead of each. Be guided by your target market, because the calendar differs by country. Avoid constant discounting; a sale that happens every month stops being a sale and starts being your price.

Channel	Cost to start	Time to results	Skill needed
SEO and blog	Low (your time)	3 to 12 months	Writing, keyword research
Social content	Low to medium	1 to 3 months	Video, editing, consistency
Email and SMS	Low	Immediate once the list grows	Copywriting, flows
Paid social	Medium to high	Days to weeks	Creative testing, analytics
Google Shopping and Search	Medium to high	Days to weeks	Feed management, bidding
Influencers	Medium	Days to weeks	Outreach, negotiation

Common mistake. Scaling ad spend before the product page converts. If visitors do not buy, more traffic only means more wasted money. Fix the store (Chapters 5, 6 and 8) before you pour in budget.

Key takeaways

- Think in a funnel: awareness, consideration, purchase and loyalty, each with its own channels.
- SEO and short-form video build long-term traffic; email builds ownership of your audience.
- Start paid ads with a capped test budget, several creatives, and ROAS against your break-even.
- Plan promotions across the year and avoid permanent discounting.

Practice task. Write a 30-second video script for one product: hook, problem, demonstration, benefit, call to action. Then write the three emails of a welcome series for the same brand. Keep both for your portfolio (Chapter 13).

CHAPTER 11

Analytics, Conversion and Growth

> Good merchants run the store by numbers. They know which channels make money, where visitors give up, and which change is worth making next. This chapter teaches the core metrics, shows how to read Shopify's reports, and gives a method for improving conversion step by step.

11.1 The reports you will use

Shopify Analytics is built in. The home page shows a summary, and the Analytics section holds detailed reports. Start with these:

- **Sales over time**: revenue, orders and average order value by day or week.
- **Acquisition**: where sessions come from (direct, search, social, email, paid).
- **Behaviour**: which pages visitors view and how far they go in the funnel.
- **Product performance**: units sold, revenue and returns per product.
- **Customers**: new versus returning customers, and repeat purchase rate.
- **Marketing**: spend, sales and return on ad spend by campaign, if you connect your channels.

For deeper analysis, connect Google Analytics 4 and the Meta pixel or Shopify's official channel apps, so every platform records purchases the same way. Expect small differences between platforms; they count attribution differently. Pick one source of truth for money (the Shopify orders report) and use the others for trends.

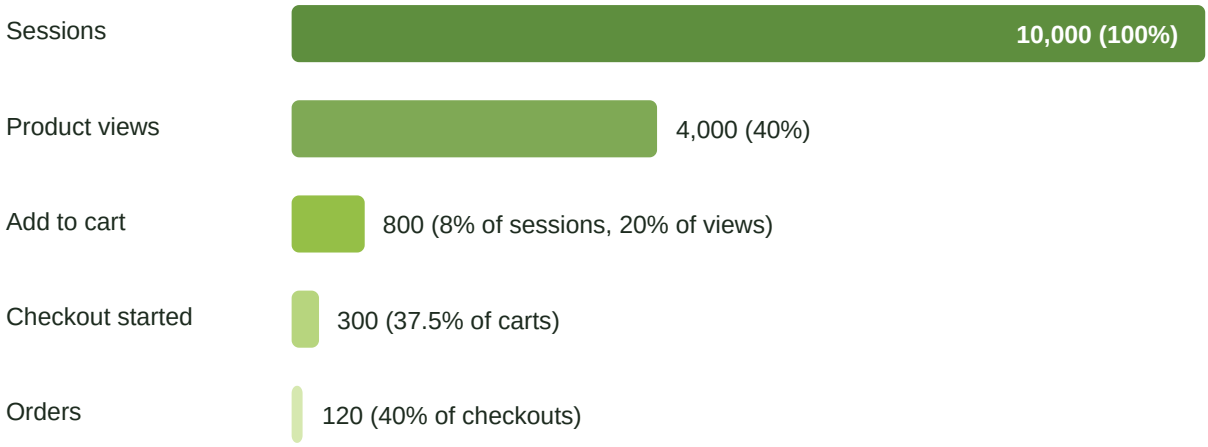
11.2 Metrics that matter

Metric	Formula	What it tells you
Conversion rate (CVR)	Orders divided by sessions	How well the store turns visits into sales
Average order value (AOV)	Revenue divided by orders	How much each order is worth
Revenue per visitor	Revenue divided by sessions	Combines CVR and AOV in one number
Customer acquisition cost (CAC)	Marketing spend divided by new customers	What it costs to win a buyer
Return on ad spend (ROAS)	Ad-attributed revenue divided by ad spend	Efficiency of paid campaigns
Customer lifetime value (LTV)	Average profit per customer over their relationship with you	How much you can afford to spend to acquire
Repeat purchase rate	Customers with two or more orders divided by all customers	Loyalty health
Cart abandonment rate	1 minus (orders divided by checkouts started)	Friction in the buying journey
Return rate	Returned units divided by units sold	Product fit, quality and expectation gaps

> **Rule of thumb.** A healthy LTV to CAC ratio for a mature e-commerce brand is often quoted as about 3 to 1, but this varies by margin, category and repeat rate. Use it as a question to ask, not as a target to hit blindly.

11.3 Reading the funnel

A conversion funnel shows where visitors leave. Figure 11.1 uses sample numbers from a small store in one month.



Conversion rate = 120 divided by 10,000 = 1.2%. Bars are not to scale below the first row.

Figure 11.1: Sample conversion funnel for one month. The largest drop is between product view and add to cart.

Read the funnel from top to bottom and ask one question at each step. A large drop from product view to add to cart suggests a product page problem: weak images, unclear price, missing reviews or poor delivery information. A large drop from checkout started to order suggests checkout friction or unexpected costs. A low sessions figure with a healthy funnel is a traffic problem, which points to marketing (Chapter 10).

11.4 Conversion improvements, in order

1. **Speed.** Fix slow pages on mobile first. This benefits every step.
2. **Product page clarity.** A clear title, price, delivery estimate, size guide and sharp photos.
3. **Social proof.** Reviews with photos, ratings near the buy button, and short testimonials.
4. **Trust.** Visible returns policy, secure payment, real contact details and a physical business address.
5. **Offers.** Free-shipping thresholds, bundles and first-order incentives, tested for margin.
6. **Checkout.** Guest checkout, express payment options and no surprise costs.

Test one change at a time. Use an A/B testing app or a controlled test, run it until you have enough orders to trust the difference, and keep notes of each result. Changes that seem obvious often fail, and small changes sometimes win big.

11.5 Building a weekly review

Every week, spend 45 minutes on this routine:

1. Compare sessions, orders, revenue, AOV and CVR with last week and the same week last year.
2. Check the funnel for the biggest drop and write one hypothesis.

3. Review the top ten and bottom ten products by revenue and return rate.
4. Check ad performance against break-even ROAS, and pause anything clearly losing money.
5. Read ten customer messages or reviews and note recurring themes.
6. Choose one action for the coming week and assign a date to it.

Common mistake. Changing five things at once and then not knowing which one worked. Also avoid judging a test after a day or two. Small stores need time and volume before results mean anything.

Key takeaways

- Know the core formulas: CVR, AOV, CAC, ROAS, LTV, repeat rate and abandonment.
- Use the funnel to find the biggest drop, then form and test one hypothesis at a time.
- Use the orders report as the source of truth for money.
- Run a short, consistent weekly review.

Practice task. Using the numbers in Figure 11.1, calculate the abandonment rate, and if AOV is 2,000, the monthly revenue. Then write down the one change you would test first and how you would know it worked.

CHAPTER 12

Scaling, International Sales and Retail

Once a store has steady orders, growth comes from new markets, new channels and better operations. This chapter introduces Shopify Markets for international selling, B2B wholesale, sales channels beyond the website, and the habits that let a small team handle more orders without losing quality.

12.1 Selling in more than one country

Shopify Markets lets one store sell in several countries. You set up a market for each region and control its currency, language, prices, payment methods, shipping and duties. Figure 12.1 shows the structure with example markets.

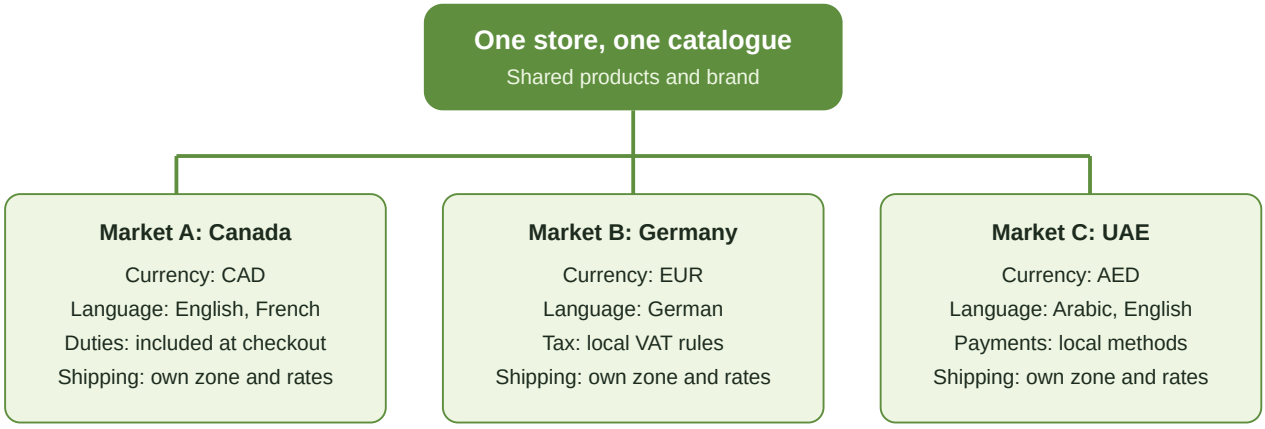


Figure 12.1: Example market structure (the markets shown are illustrations; check what your plan and payment provider support)

Before you expand, check these points:

- **Demand and competition** in the new country. Use the same search and ad-library research as Chapter 2.
- **Shipping cost and speed**. International parcels can cost more than your product margin allows. Test with a limited range first.
- **Duties and import rules**. Some products face high duties, restrictions or certification requirements. Decide who pays duties, and state it clearly.
- **Returns from abroad**. Return costs can exceed the value of the item. Many stores set no-return rules for low-value international orders, but this must be clear before purchase and allowed by local law.
- **Language quality**. Machine translation without review damages trust. Use a professional or native speaker for product copy and policies.
- **Payments and local preferences**. Offer the payment methods people use in that country.

12.2 Wholesale and B2B

Business customers buy differently: larger quantities, negotiated prices, invoices and payment terms. Shopify's B2B features (available on higher-tier plans) support company accounts, customer-specific catalogues, price lists and wholesale ordering. Even on a smaller plan, you can handle wholesale enquiries by email with a simple

price list and a minimum order quantity. Set minimums that cover your handling costs, and check that wholesale pricing does not undercut your own retail prices in a way that damages the brand.

12.3 Sales channels beyond your website

Shopify connects your catalogue to several places where customers already shop:

Channel	Good for	Trade-off
Shopify POS	Pop-up shops, retail stores, market stalls, events	Needs hardware and inventory discipline across locations
Social shopping (Instagram, Facebook, TikTok, Pinterest)	Impulse buys from content	Platform rules and changing features
Google shopping listings	Shoppers already searching for your product	Requires clean product data and competitive pricing
Marketplaces (Amazon, eBay, Daraz and others, via apps or connectors)	Reach and trust among shoppers who start on marketplaces	Fees, competition, strict rules, less brand control
Wholesale and B2B	Volume orders	Pricing discipline and credit risk

Add channels one at a time. Each one needs product data, stock sync and customer service. A new channel that sells out your stock and leaves you unable to fulfil orders damages your reputation everywhere.

12.4 Operations that scale

- **Write standard operating procedures (SOPs)** for every repeated task: adding a product, handling a refund, responding to a delivery complaint. A checklist lets someone else do the job correctly.
- **Use a shared inbox** for customer messages with clear response targets, such as first reply within one working day.
- **Automate the repeatable** with Shopify Flow and apps, but keep a human check for refunds, disputes and high-value orders.
- **Track stock weekly** and set reorder points based on lead time and sales speed.
- **Protect cash flow.** Stock purchases often happen weeks before revenue arrives. Forecast cash needs monthly and never commit more to stock than you can pay for from the next weeks of sales.
- **Hire or outsource slowly.** Start with a virtual assistant for order admin or content, then add specialists when a task fills a full working week.

Key takeaways

- Expand internationally only after checking demand, shipping, duties, returns and language quality.
- Shopify Markets manages currencies, languages and prices for each market from one store.
- Wholesale and new sales channels add reach but add operational load; add them one at a time.
- Scaling depends on SOPs, clear service standards and careful cash-flow planning.

Practice task. Choose one country that is not your home market. Research demand for one product using search data and competitor listings, list three shipping or duty issues you would have to solve, and write a one-page go or no-go recommendation.

CHAPTER 13

Building an E-commerce Career with Shopify

> Shopify skills open several career paths: running stores for businesses, building themes and apps, specialising in conversion or advertising, or running your own agency. This chapter maps the roles, explains what employers and clients look for, and gives you a practical route from beginner to first paid work.

13.1 The career map

E-commerce is a broad field, and people enter it from many backgrounds: retail, marketing, design, customer service, accounting or no specific background at all. Figure 13.1 shows a common progression. Most people move up by adding a specialism, showing results and taking responsibility for money or outcomes.

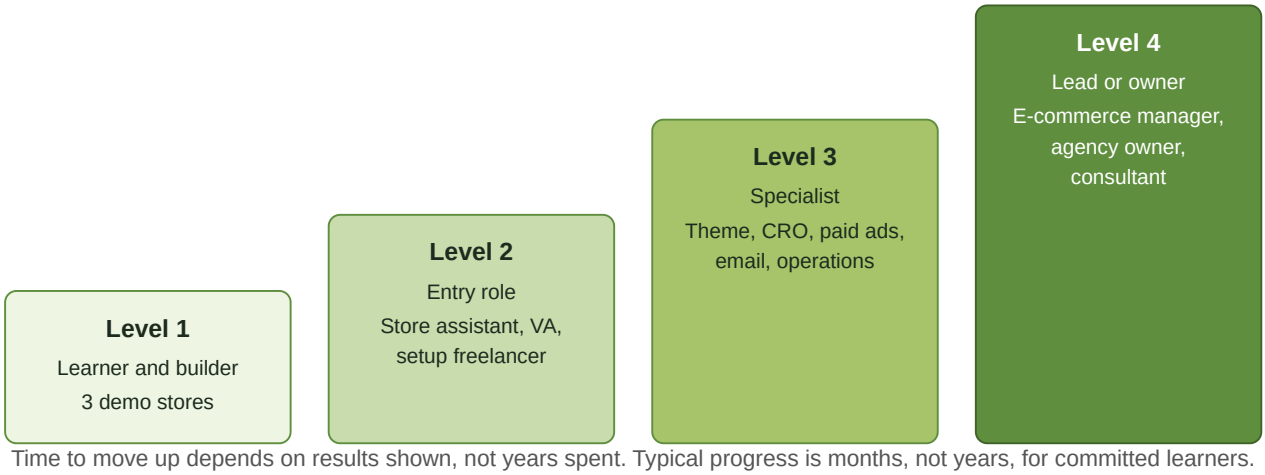


Figure 13.1: Career progression in Shopify and e-commerce

13.2 The main roles

Role	What the person does	Key skills
Store setup specialist	Builds and launches stores for clients	Admin, themes, apps, payments, checklists
E-commerce executive or store manager	Runs a brand's store day to day, including orders, catalogue, promotions and reports	Operations, analytics, customer service, planning
Shopify theme developer	Customises and builds themes and sections using Liquid, HTML, CSS and JavaScript	Front-end code, Liquid, Git, Shopify CLI
Shopify app developer	Builds apps using Shopify APIs and webhooks	Back-end development, APIs, security, GraphQL
Conversion rate optimiser (CRO)	Runs tests and improves funnel performance	Analytics, UX, testing, copywriting

Paid media specialist	Plans and optimises paid campaigns for stores	Ad platforms, creative testing, ROAS analysis
Email and CRM specialist	Builds flows, segments and retention programmes	Copywriting, segmentation, email tools
Content and social specialist	Produces product content, video and social posts	Photography, video editing, copywriting
Operations and fulfilment coordinator	Manages stock, suppliers, shipping and returns	Spreadsheets, logistics, supplier communication
E-commerce consultant or agency owner	Sells services to several brands	Client management, sales, pricing, multiple specialisms

13.3 Learning resources

Use free resources first, then pay only for depth you can apply:

- **Shopify's own learning content**, including Shopify Academy courses and Partner Academy materials. Course catalogues change, so check what is currently available.
- **Shopify's documentation** for the admin, themes, APIs and CLI. Reading docs is a real skill for developers and for managers.
- **Hands-on practice** in development stores. A development store is free to create through the Partner Program and lets you test features without a paid plan.
- **Analytics courses** such as Google's free training in Google Analytics and Google Ads, and the free courses from Meta's own learning hub.
- **Industry communities**, creator channels and case studies from merchants who publish their numbers.

Certificates are a useful signal, especially for people with no work history, but a portfolio of real work will do more for your hiring chances than certificates alone.

13.4 Join the Shopify Partner Program

The Shopify Partner Program is free to join. Partners get a partner dashboard, development stores for building and testing, access to partner resources, and the ability to earn from client plans and referrals under the programme's current terms. Check the terms before you rely on any income figure. Joining is one of the most practical first steps for anyone who wants to build client stores.

13.5 Build a portfolio that proves skill

Employers and clients want evidence. Build three types of project:

1. **Three demo stores** in different niches on development stores. Each should have at least ten products with variants, a custom home page, policies, shipping rules, a working checkout test and a short Loom or video walk-through.
2. **One redesign case study.** Take a real store (with permission, or a public example, changed to avoid copying brand assets) and write a before-and-after analysis: problems you found, changes you made, and what you would test next.
3. **One real or pilot project**, even if unpaid at first: help a friend's business set up a store, improve a product page or run a small ad test, then report the results honestly.

Present each project with the same structure: the problem, your role, what you did, the result and what you learned. Results can be modest, such as a 15 percent lift in add-to-cart rate, but the reasoning must be clear.

13.6 Getting your first paid work

- **Freelance platforms.** Upwork, Fiverr and similar sites list many Shopify jobs. Start with narrow, clearly defined services, such as "Shopify store setup for small brands" or "product upload and SEO for 50 products". Clear scope wins more clients than general claims.
- **Local businesses.** Many small shops in your city need help with online sales. Offer a fixed-price setup package and a monthly support plan.
- **Networks and referrals.** Tell people you know what you can do. Your first clients are often friends of friends.
- **Job applications.** Look for roles titled e-commerce executive, Shopify specialist, digital marketing executive (e-commerce focus), online store coordinator, or CRO analyst. Read each job description and match your portfolio to the top three requirements.

13.7 Pricing your services

New freelancers often underprice. Price around the value you create and the time you spend, and be clear about what is included. Common models are:

Model	Example	Best for
Fixed-price project	Store setup with ten products, theme customisation and launch checklist	Clear, bounded work
Monthly retainer	Weekly catalogue updates, monthly report, two campaign tests	Ongoing management
Hourly rate	Troubleshooting, consulting, short fixes	Unclear or small tasks
Performance element	Base fee plus a share of verified growth	Experienced marketers with strong data access (use caution and clear terms)

Always write a scope of work that lists deliverables, exclusions, timelines, the number of revision rounds, payment terms and who owns the content and accounts at the end.

13.8 Interview and client conversation basics

Interviewers want to know whether you can solve their problems. Prepare short, concrete answers to these questions:

- *"How would you improve our product page?"* Describe the funnel, one hypothesis, the change, and how you would measure it.
- *"Walk me through setting up a new store."* Use the checklist in Chapter 3, and mention policies, payments and testing.
- *"A customer says their order is late. What do you do?"* Check the tracking, contact the customer proactively, offer a clear next step, and log the issue to find a pattern.
- *"Which metrics do you look at first?"* Sessions, conversion rate, AOV, margin, and ROAS, in that order, with a reason for each.

13.9 A realistic first-year plan

1. **Months 1 to 3:** Complete this course, build three demo stores, join the Partner Program and document each project publicly or in a private portfolio.
2. **Months 4 to 6:** Complete the redesign case study, do one pilot project for a real business, and apply for 20 relevant roles or pitch 20 local businesses.
3. **Months 7 to 9:** Take one paid project or one junior role. Specialise in one area you enjoy most and keep learning in that area.
4. **Months 10 to 12:** Gather testimonials, raise your prices for new clients, and build a repeatable process: intake form, scope, build checklist, launch checklist and handover.

Results depend heavily on consistency, communication and the quality of your work. Be cautious of any claim that promises fast or guaranteed income from e-commerce. The businesses that succeed usually make careful choices, track their numbers and keep improving.

Key takeaways

- E-commerce careers range from store operations and marketing to development and agency ownership.
- Build a portfolio of three demo stores, one case study and one real project.
- Specialise, price for value, and write clear scopes of work.
- Prepare concrete answers in interviews and client conversations, backed by the metrics from Chapter 11.

Practice task. Write your own one-page career plan: the role you are aiming for in 12 months, the two skills you will strengthen, the three portfolio projects you will build, and the five places you will look for work.

CHAPTER 14

Capstone Project and 90-Day Action Plan

> The final chapter brings everything together. You will launch a small but complete store, measure it, present it as a portfolio piece, and follow a 90-day plan that turns this course into a working habit.

14.1 The capstone brief

Build a store for one product category of your choice. You may use a development store or a live store with a small test budget, as long as you respect local law and do not sell prohibited items. Your deliverables are:

1. **Business plan (one page)**, following Chapter 2, with unit economics for at least three products.
2. **Store setup** completed through all nine steps in Chapter 3.
3. **Catalogue** of 10 to 15 products, with variants, complete descriptions, photos and SEO fields (Chapter 5).
4. **Theme** customised with a home page, product template, collection page and mobile check (Chapter 6).
5. **Apps**: no more than three, each justified in writing (Chapter 7).
6. **Policies, shipping and tax settings** reviewed against Chapters 8 and 9.
7. **Marketing plan**: one welcome email sequence of three emails and one short video script (Chapter 10).
8. **Analytics setup** and a weekly review template, with one hypothesis tested (Chapter 11).
9. **Presentation**: a five-minute walk-through (video or slides) explaining the store, the numbers and what you would do next.

14.2 Capstone marking guide

Area	Excellent (4)	Developing (2)	Missing (0)
Business logic	Clear model, realistic unit economics, legal checklist completed	Model chosen but numbers incomplete	No plan or numbers
Store setup	All checklist items complete and tested with a full test order	Most items done, some untested	Incomplete or untested
Catalogue quality	Variants used correctly, benefit-led copy, clear photos, SEO fields complete	Some fields missing or copy generic	Few products or poor data
Design	Clear hierarchy, mobile-first, fast pages, consistent style	Works but cluttered or slow	Broken on mobile
Marketing and analytics	Funnel explained, flows written, test hypothesis clear	Partial plan or metrics without decisions	Missing
Presentation	Clear, honest, and specific about what to do next	Clear but lacks evidence	Unclear or unrealistic claims

14.3 The 90-day action plan

Figure 14.1 lays out a 13-week plan that moves you from learning to portfolio and job search. Each bar is a focus area; work on one or two at a time, and keep a weekly review.

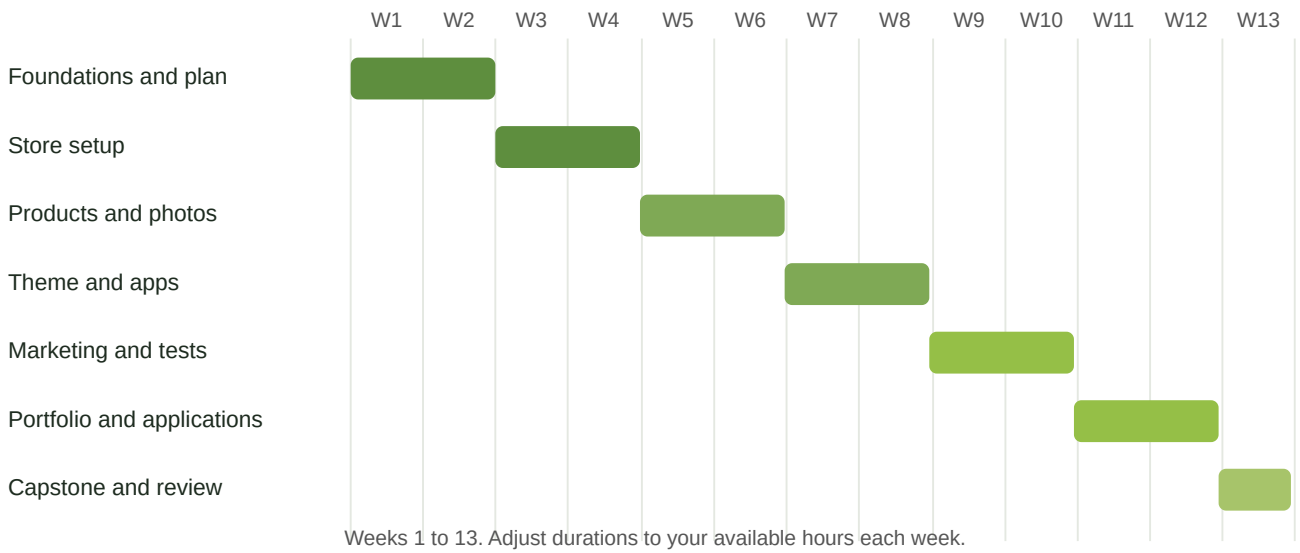


Figure 14.1: 90-day plan (about 13 weeks) from foundations to portfolio and job search

In practice, the plan works like this:

- **Weeks 1 to 2:** finish the business plan, pick a niche, and complete Chapters 1 to 2.
- **Weeks 3 to 4:** set up the store, payments, shipping, taxes and policies.
- **Weeks 5 to 6:** build the catalogue, photograph products and write descriptions.
- **Weeks 7 to 8:** customise the theme, add at most three apps, and run a mobile and speed check.
- **Weeks 9 to 10:** build the welcome emails, set up analytics, run a small test and review results weekly.
- **Weeks 11 to 12:** write the case study, polish the portfolio and send your first applications or proposals.
- **Week 13:** present your capstone, gather feedback, and set the next 90-day goal.

14.4 Self-check quiz

Answer these questions without looking back. The answers follow.

1. What is the difference between payment status and fulfilment status in the admin?
2. Name the three parts of a Liquid tag and what each does.
3. Write the formula for conversion rate and for break-even ROAS.
4. Why should you duplicate a theme before editing it?
5. Name two reasons to avoid installing many apps.
6. When should you offer free shipping, and what threshold logic is useful?
7. What is the main difference between a manual and an automated collection?
8. Why might a store with a healthy funnel still have low sales?

Answers.

1. Payment status shows whether money was received (paid, pending, refunded). Fulfilment status shows whether the items were shipped (unfulfilled, fulfilled).
2. {{ ... }} outputs a value; {% ... %} runs logic such as if-statements and loops; | passes a value through a filter such as money.
3. CVR = orders divided by sessions. Break-even ROAS = 1 divided by contribution margin percentage (before ads).
4. So customers keep seeing the working live version while you test, and you can roll back if the edit breaks something.
5. Apps add scripts that slow the store, cost money every month, can conflict with each other, and create more logins and risk.
6. Offer free shipping when it raises order value enough to cover the shipping cost. Set the threshold slightly above the average order value so customers add a small extra item.
7. A manual collection holds only the products you add by hand; an automated collection adds products that match rules and updates itself.
8. The conversion rate can look healthy while total sales stay small, because the store gets too few visitors. Check sessions and audience as well as ratios. If visitors arrive but do not buy, look at price, offer clarity and product-market fit.

Key takeaways

- A capstone turns separate skills into one working, measurable store.
- Judge your work against clear criteria: business logic, setup, catalogue, design, marketing and presentation.
- Follow a 90-day plan, reviewing progress every week.
- The most valuable outcome is a portfolio that proves what you can do.

Final task. Launch or demonstrate your capstone store, record a five-minute walk-through, and write a one-page reflection: what worked, what you would change, and what your next 90-day goal is.

APPENDIX

Glossary of Terms

Term	Meaning
3PL	Third-party logistics: an outside company that stores and ships your products
A/B test	Showing two versions of a page or message to different visitors to see which performs better
Abandoned cart	A cart where the customer left before completing payment
Admin API	Shopify's interface for apps and integrations to read and write store data
AOV	Average order value
Attribution	The method used to credit a sale to a marketing source
Chargeback	A customer's bank reversing a card payment, usually after a dispute
Collection	A group of products on your store
Compare-at price	The original price shown crossed out next to the sale price
Conversion rate	Share of sessions that end in an order
Cut-off time	The time after which orders ship the next working day
Dispatch	The point when a parcel leaves your control with the carrier
Duties	Taxes charged on goods when they cross a border
Fulfilment	All steps from order to delivery
GMV	Gross merchandise value: total value of goods sold, before refunds and discounts
Liquid	The open template language used by Shopify themes
Metafield	Custom data attached to a product, collection or other object
Payout	Transfer of funds from a payment provider to your bank account
ROAS	Return on ad spend: revenue from ads divided by ad spend
SKU	Stock keeping unit: your internal code for a variant
Storefront API	Shopify's interface for building custom shopping front-ends
Theme	A template that controls the look and layout of the storefront
Variant	A specific version of a product, such as a size and colour combination
Webhook	A message sent automatically when an event happens in the store, such as an order being created